of those who had no other means left to give expression to their heart-rending agony. Our sole purpose was “to make the deaf hear”.’

The attack on the Delhi Assembly killed no one, and nor was it intended to, but it did cause minor injuries. Bhagat Singh and B.K. Dutt had to give an explanation, namely, that it was ‘to give the heedless a timely warning’,[5] given that members of the assembly on that day included Motilal Nehru (the father of Jawaharlal Nehru), Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, Muhammad Ali Jinnah, Madan Mohan Malaviya and John Simon (of the Simon Commission). However, ‘[w]e bore no personal grudge or malice against any one of those who received slight injuries or against any other person in the Assembly’ and this is why ‘the two bombs exploded in vacant spaces within wooden barriers of desks and benches’ and why ‘even those who were within two-feet of the explosion were either not hurt or only slightly scratched’.[6]

Second, the redacted portions of the statement reveal why these two members of the HSRA chose to target the Delhi legislature itself. As they state,

> Our practical protest was against the institution which since its birth has eminently helped to display not only its worthlessness but its far-reaching power for mischief. The more we have pondered the more deeply we have been convinced that it exists only to demonstrate to the world India’s humiliation and helplessness and it symbolises the overriding domination of an irresponsible and autocratic rule. Time and again the national demand has been pressed by the people’s representatives only to find the waste-paper basket as its final destination.[7]

It is small wonder that this incendiary denunciation of the assembly was expunged from the record. But it did not end there. As the two of them continued, ‘In spite of earnest endeavour we have utterly failed to find any justification for the existence of an institution which despite all the pomp and splendour organised with the hard-earned money of the sweating millions of India is only a hollow show and a mischievous make-believe.’ Their excoriating damnation ended with a reference to ‘the public leaders who help to squander public time and money on such a manifestly stage-managed an exhibition of India’s helpless subjection’. In subsequent parts